

ular entities before the latter could, and then sell it to the needy parties at a higher cost than that charged by InterNIC. This activity, called Cybersquatting, was curbed when the courts ruled that trademarked names were out of bounds for cybersquatters. But “business” was not a trademarked word. The buyer, ecompanies, was (is) a venture capitalist.

The Y2K bug

Though commonly referred to as a bug, technically it isn't one. Early programmers consciously used only two bits, rather than four, to represent a year to save memory. So rather than record a year as 1974, programs recorded “74”. And since memory was at a premium, the savings were welcome. In the year 2000 (or Y2K), these programs would only consider “00”, rather than “2000”. It is easy to see that calculations involving dates in the different millennia would have erroneous results. This issue effected all software programs as well as all devices using embedded chips with firmware that used the 2-bit limitation. It was feared that when the new millennium arrived, chaos would reign since computers and embedded chips were pervasive. The solution involved going through programs' source and finding the areas where the date field was set to 2 bits and changing it to 4. Due to the pervasive nature of the problem, there arose a strong demand for computer engineers. Since most of the old programs were coded in languages like COBOL and FORTRAN, people who had experience in these were in much demand. Engineering students in India were still being taught these languages as part of their curriculum, and found themselves in an ideal position.

In many ways the Indian IT companies found the Y2K phenomenon advantageous since it offered a great opportunity to showcase their coding skills.